

The Architecture of Grace

BOOK ONE · THE FOUNDATION



Autism-Adapted Edition

Visual Anchor Charts

TEACHER SUPPLEMENT

Grades K–2 · Early Childhood

Designed for autistic learners with lower support needs · one chart per page

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Before You Begin

What changed, what didn't, and why

This supplement is not a new curriculum. It is the same fourteen anchor charts from *Architecture of Grace · Book One · The Foundation*, rebuilt by a multidisciplinary team — autism specialist, school psychologist, school social worker, special education teacher, speech-language pathologist, and occupational therapist — with autistic learners with lower support needs held as the design audience from the first line.

What did NOT change

- Every defined construct — *Grace, Forgiveness, Trust, Mercy, Oops* vs. *"I Am Bad," Kind Coach, Grumpy Gus, Sammy* — appears exactly as the curriculum defines it.
- The theoretical foundation — Brown's shame/guilt research, Neff's self-compassion, Enright & Fitzgibbons' forgiveness model, Worthington's REACH — is preserved.
- The pedagogy — Sammy as relational anchor, anchor charts built WITH students, Family Connection, Disclosure Protocol — is unchanged.

What is new in every chart

- **A literal-language anchor.** Each metaphor is also stated plainly, so a child who processes language literally has a foothold into the lesson.
- **Body-first interoception scaffolding** on every emotion-related chart. *Where do I feel it?* precedes *What does it mean?*
- **Scripted sentence frames printed visibly on the chart** — reducing in-the-moment language production load.
- **A Specialist Note** at the bottom of each chart, written to the teacher about what to watch for, what to honor, and what to never force.

One protective addition, in two places

The Pause Practice (U4 · L3) and the Forgiveness vs. Trust chart (U3 · L3) carry an added line each: a pattern-tracking guardrail. Autistic children are statistically more likely to be bullied and disbelieved; the original “choose the kind story” framing — without this guardrail — can train a child to override accurate threat detection. The construct is unchanged. The guardrail is new.

A NOTE ON LANGUAGE

“Level 1,” “mild-to-moderate,” “high-functioning,” and “lower support needs” all describe the same population. We use *lower support needs* in this edition, in line with current clinical and self-advocate consensus. No child's support needs are static — a child who looks lower-support at recess may need more support in a fire drill. Design accordingly.

My Identity Web

Who I Am — All the Pieces of Me

Build one branch at a time · Each branch is a different part of who you are



SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Branch 4 (originally “My SPECIAL Thing”) has been renamed *Things That Make Me FEEL GOOD* — this opens space for sensory regulators (a favorite texture, a quiet corner, stim toys, a specific song) to be named as part of identity, not as something separate or weird. *Special interests in Branch 1 should be welcomed at full intensity — these are not distractions from identity; they are identity.* Build one branch at a time. Post BEFORE the worksheet. Keep posted all year.

Feelings Are Messengers

First I find it in my body · Then I name it · Then I listen

Feelings are not problems. Feelings are information about what is happening inside us.

THREE STEPS · IN ORDER

1. *Where in my body do I feel it?* · 2. *What is its name?* · 3. *What does my body need now?*

HAPPY

often: warm chest · easy breath · wanting to move

Something good is happening. I am safe.

SAD

often: heavy chest · wet eyes · tired arms

Something I care about was lost or hurt. I might need a hug or a quiet space.

ANGRY

often: hot face · tight hands · loud chest

Something feels unfair. I might need help, or space, or to move.

SCARED

often: fast heart · cold belly · wanting to be small

Something feels unsafe. My body wants to keep me safe.

OVERWHELMED · TOO MUCH

often: noisy head · tight chest · everything is loud or bright

There is too much coming in. I need less — fewer sounds, fewer people, a break.

PROUD

often: tall back · warm face · wanting to show someone

I did something hard. I worked through it.

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Many autistic children have *interoception differences* — the inside-the-body sense that delivers feeling-data is quieter or differently mapped. The original chart asks “*What is this feeling trying to tell me?*” — a question that requires the body signal to arrive first. We added the body-first step ahead of naming. Some children will say “*I don’t feel it anywhere*” — that is honest data, not non-compliance. Accept it. The “OVERWHELMED · TOO MUCH” card is new and essential — it is not a moral failure; it is a sensory load report.

Oops → Fix It → Try Again

A mistake is something that happened — it is not who you are

*When something goes wrong, follow the three steps.
Mistakes are how we grow.*

I
OOPS

Something went wrong.

A mistake happened. That is okay. *Words I can say:* “I made a mistake.”

2
FIX IT

Pick one thing to do.

Choose one — you do not have to do all three: · Say sorry · Fix the thing · Try a different way
Words I can say: “I will ____.”

3
TRY AGAIN

You can do it.

Everyone makes mistakes — kids, grown-ups, even Sammy. *Words I can say:* “I will try again.”

A mistake is not who you are.
It is something that happened.

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Each step now carries a printed sentence frame the child can read, repeat, or point to. For many autistic children, knowing *the exact words to say* in a hard moment is the difference between being able to use the strategy and freezing. The framework is unchanged. *Some children will need to walk through all three steps verbally even when they already know them — the verbal walkthrough is the regulation, not the lesson. Honor it.*

Kind Coach vs. Grumpy Gus

Two voices we can hear inside our own head

WHAT THIS MEANS — IN PLAIN WORDS

Sammy is a puppet. A grown-up holds Sammy and gives him two different voices. The voices are not real people. They are how we practice noticing the voices in our own head. *Everyone has both voices inside.* The lesson is to notice which one is talking — and choose the kind one.

× GRUMPY GUS	✓ KIND COACH
Talks about who I AM. “You ARE bad.”	Talks about what I DID. “Oops — try again.”
Says BIG always / never words. “You ALWAYS mess up.” “You’ll NEVER get it.”	Is specific · honest · kind. “What can I learn?” “What is one next step?”
Points toward: hiding · feeling small	Points toward: fixing · growing

THE KIND COACH ASKS THREE QUESTIONS

1. What happened? 2. What can I learn? 3. What is one next step?

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Some autistic K-2 students process the puppet literally — they may believe Sammy is the source of the voices, not a tool for noticing the voices inside themselves. The plain-words box above states the metaphor explicitly. *For some children, you may need to say it once more during the lesson:* “Sammy is a puppet. The voices live in our own heads. Sammy helps us see them.” Color-code red/green when co-building. Post permanently. Reference every lesson for the rest of the year.

Oops vs. “I Am Bad”

The most important distinction in this whole curriculum

One points us toward fixing. The other points us toward hiding.

✓ OOPS	⚠ “I AM BAD” · DANGER
About what I DID.	About who I AM.
One moment. A mistake. It can be fixed.	A story about me. Never true about a person.
Points toward repair. “Fix it. Try again.”	Points toward hiding. “Why even try?”
Sounds like: “I made a bad CHOICE.”	Sounds like: “I am a bad PERSON.”

WHEN YOU HEAR GRUMPY GUS · ASK

“Is this about my **BEHAVIOR** or my **IDENTITY**?”

A NOTE FOR EVERYONE IN THIS ROOM

Sometimes people in the world say unkind things about who we ARE — that we are weird, too much, too quiet, too loud, wrong. **Those people are wrong about you.** What they say is in the “I AM BAD” column — and that column is never true about a person. *You are allowed to be who you are. Always.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Many autistic children arrive at this lesson having already absorbed years of “you are weird / rude / too much / not listening” feedback — and have already begun to fuse identity with behavior. The added note above is for them, and for every child. It must be read aloud as part of the lesson. *Watch for children who go very still or look away during this lesson — note privately, follow Disclosure Protocol if anything else surfaces.* Post BEFORE the sorting activity. When a child uses shame language, point to the chart: “Which column is that in?”

Forgiveness Myth Busters

The Heavy Backpack — what forgiveness is NOT, and what it IS

WHAT “HEAVY BACKPACK” MEANS — IN PLAIN WORDS

A real backpack gets heavy with books. Our inside gets heavy too — with angry feelings about something that hurt us. The backpack is a picture for how that heaviness feels. Forgiveness is choosing to put down some of that weight, for YOU.

What Forgiveness is NOT

- ✗ **Myth 1.** Forgiveness does NOT mean forgetting what happened.
- ✗ **Myth 2.** Forgiveness does NOT mean what happened was okay.
- ✗ **Myth 3.** Forgiveness is NOT weakness — it takes more courage than holding on to anger.
- ✗ **Myth 4.** You do NOT have to feel ready before you start — forgiveness is a decision, not a feeling.
- ✗ **Myth 5.** You do NOT have to forgive someone who is still hurting you. (Safety first. Always.)

WHAT FORGIVENESS IS

*Forgiveness is letting go of angry feelings —
not to say what happened was okay,
but to free **YOURSELF** from carrying the weight of it.
For us. Not for the person who hurt us.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Myth 5 is new. The original four myths come from Enright & Fitzgibbons. The fifth is a safety floor — many autistic children are statistically more likely to be pressured (by peers, by adults) to “just forgive” someone who is still hurting them, and the original Book 1 chart did not state this guardrail explicitly. It must be on the chart. *The plain-words box at the top is for children who will picture a literal backpack and miss the metaphor — read it aloud.* Use the backpack prop as the curriculum specifies; the prop is still good pedagogy, the literal anchor just makes it accessible.

The Three-Part Real Sorry

A real sorry has three parts — all three matter

“Sorry” without all three parts is a start — not a finish.

I PART ONE	NAME WHAT HAPPENED “I ____.” Honest. Not vague. Say the actual thing you did. Example: “I knocked your tower over.”
2 PART TWO	NAME THE HURT “I know that made you feel ____.” Show that you understand how the other person felt. Example: “I know that made you feel sad.”
3 PART THREE	NAME THE CHANGE “Next time I will ____ instead.” A real promise — not just “I’m sorry.” Example: “Next time I will walk around the tower.”

EVEN IF I DIDN'T MEAN TO HURT THEM

If I did not mean to hurt someone — but they got hurt anyway — I can still say a real sorry for the hurt.

My reason doesn't erase their feeling.

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Two changes from the original: (1) each step now carries a concrete example, because autistic children often need a worked example to bridge from frame to use; (2) the “even if I didn’t mean to” call-out is critical — many autistic children get stuck on intent (“but I didn’t MEAN to”) and freeze on apology because they read it as admitting they did something on purpose. Teaching that *impact and intent are separate* at K-2 is doing them a real favor for the rest of their lives. Post before distributing the worksheet. Walk through each step as a class.

Three Parts of Being Kind to Yourself

Talk to yourself like you would a good friend

What would you say to a friend who felt this way? Say it to yourself instead.

I

PART ONE

SELF-KINDNESS

“I care about you.”

Speak to yourself with care, not meanness — like you would talk to a good friend.

Words I can say to myself: “It’s okay. I care about you. This is hard.”

2

PART TWO

COMMON HUMANITY

“Everyone goes through hard things.”

You are not alone. Everyone makes mistakes. Everyone hurts sometimes.

Words I can say to myself: “Other people feel this way too. I am not the only one.”

3

PART THREE

MINDFULNESS

“I notice I am feeling ___.”

See the feeling clearly. Don’t push it away — but don’t drown in it either.

Words I can say to myself: “Right now I feel _____. That is real. It will not last forever.”

Adapted from Dr. Kristin Neff’s Self-Compassion framework

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The prompt “What would you say to a friend?” assumes a level of social-emotional perspective-taking that not every autistic K–2 child has yet — and a child who is rarely treated kindly by friends has no model to draw from. Each step now carries the exact words a child can say to themselves, printed visibly. Children may want to use the scripts verbatim for months before generating their own — that is the lesson working, not a failure to internalize it. Reference in every Unit 2 lesson.

When Self-Forgiveness Feels Hard

What to do when the heavy feeling keeps coming back

Self-forgiveness is a practice, not a destination. You keep choosing it.

I
STEP ONE

When the bad feeling comes back, you can put it down again.

It is allowed to come back. Each time it comes back, you put it down again. *That is the practice — not a failure.*

2
STEP TWO

Talk to someone on your Support Web.

You do not need to carry this alone. A trusted grown-up can help. *If you are not sure who, point to your Support Web.*

3
STEP THREE

Use the Three Parts of Being Kind to Yourself.

Self-kindness · Common humanity · Mindfulness. *Look at the chart in our room.*

4
STEP FOUR

Ask the question.

“Have I done what fixing it requires?” *If yes — the punishing feelings can stop. You have done the work.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The original chart used “put it down” as a metaphor without explanation — that can confuse a literal-processing child who wonders *what* they’re putting down and *where*. The body of the chart now keeps the same metaphor but pairs it with the concrete actions a child actually takes. Steps point back to existing classroom anchors (Support Web from U2 L6, Three Parts chart from U2 L4) — autistic children often retain skills better when the chart explicitly says *which other tool to use*. Walk through each step. Keep posted through Unit 2.

Forgiveness vs. Trust

Two separate decisions

FORGIVENESS	TRUST
✓ Inside — for your own peace ✓ Can happen alone, in your own heart ✓ Needs nothing from the other person ✓ Frees YOU from carrying anger ✓ A gift you give yourself	✓ Between people — for the safety of the relationship ✓ Needs both people to be ready ✓ Needs the other person to show change <i>over time</i> ✓ Never owed — you don’t have to give it ✓ Earned through real change · watched over time

*You can forgive someone **and** still choose not to be close to them.*
*Forgiveness is for your peace. **Trust is earned — never owed.***

PATTERNS ARE INFORMATION

If someone hurts you **one time** and shows real change — that is one story.

If someone hurts you **over and over** and keeps saying sorry but does not change — **that pattern is information.**

You can notice patterns. You are allowed to notice patterns.

*Forgiveness is **never required** when someone is still hurting you.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The “Patterns are information” panel is new and essential. Autistic children are often coached (at home, in friendships, by other adults) to give endless second chances — and may struggle to weigh single events against the pattern. The panel teaches them that *noticing a pattern is allowed, valid, and a form of intelligence*. The rest of the chart preserves the curriculum’s original forgiveness/trust distinction (Enright & Fitzgibbons). Build WITH students through co-construction. Color-code columns. Keep posted for the rest of Unit 3.

The Forgiveness Path

It is not a straight line · Wherever you are is okay

WHAT “PATH” MEANS — IN PLAIN WORDS

A path is a way of getting somewhere. This path is not on the ground — it is inside. You can move forward. You can move backward. You can stay in one place. All of those are okay.

1

STILL HURTING

The hurt is new or feels really big. Your hurt is real.

2

STARTING TO UNDERSTAND

You can see why it happened — even if that doesn’t make it okay.

3

SOME DAYS ARE BETTER

The hurt comes and goes. You are in the practice.

4

PUTTING IT DOWN TODAY

A real choice — not forever yet, but real.

5

THE HURT IS SMALLER

It still exists, but it has less power.

6

I AM OKAY

You remember what happened — without it holding you down.

*Moving **backward** on the path is not failure — it is the practice. You put it down again. Each time, you get a little better at it.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Autistic children often have strong justice-sensitivity and may resist the idea of “moving forward” past a hurt that has not been acknowledged. The plain-words box at the top explicitly says *staying in one place is okay* — many autistic children stop hearing the lesson the moment they feel pressured to progress. The path is unchanged from the original. *If a child consistently places their dot on Step 1 across multiple lessons, that is information — follow Disclosure Protocol if anything else surfaces, but staying at Step 1 is not pathology by itself.* The dot placement is always anonymous. “Is that okay?” — the answer is always yes.

My Three-Panel Story

My story is real — AND I am more than my story

PANEL 1 · WHAT HAPPENED

ALWAYS PRIVATE

Something that happened to me. A real hurt or hard experience.

I do not have to share this. Ever. Not even with the teacher. Not even with Sammy.

PANEL 2 · THE STORY I TOLD

The story I told myself about what it means.

What did I decide about myself because of what happened?

This story is a BELIEF — not always the truth.

PANEL 3 · WHO I AM NOW

Who I am right now. What I have learned. What I carry.

I am MORE than Panel 1.

YOUR STORY IS REAL — AND YOU ARE MORE THAN YOUR STORY.

Panel 1 is always private. Panel 2 is a belief — not always the truth. Panel 3 is who you are becoming.

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Panel 1's privacy line has been strengthened: *not even the teacher, not even Sammy*. Autistic children — especially those who comply readily with adults — may share things in writing that they would never have shared verbally, simply because the adult asked. This chart must make absolutely clear that the worksheet stays with the child. *If you see a child looking distressed during this lesson, the answer is never to ask what they wrote — the answer is to check in privately about how they are doing, and to follow Disclosure Protocol if needed.* Panel 1 is always private. Period.

Grace vs. Doormat

The critical distinction · Grace is a CHOICE — not a rule

WHAT “DOORMAT” MEANS — IN PLAIN WORDS

A doormat is the rug by the door. People wipe their shoes on it. It has no choice. Being a “doormat” with people means letting people treat you badly because you feel you can’t say no. That is not grace. That is being used.

GRACE	DOORMAT
✓ A real choice	✗ Having no choice at all
✓ Giving from a place of strength	✗ Accepting being treated badly because of fear
✓ You can say no when you need to	✗ You feel you cannot say no
✓ Protects your dignity AND is kind	✗ Gives up your dignity for someone else’s comfort
✓ You decide what to give	✗ Others take what they want

— GRACE IS —

Giving something generous — kindness, patience, a second chance — **to someone who has not earned it.**

A choice, not a rule. A strength, not a weakness.

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

“Doormat” is a metaphor that can be opaque to literal-processing children — the plain-words box at the top names it directly. The distinction itself is preserved from the original Book 1 chart. This chart is particularly important for autistic children, who are statistically more likely to be taken advantage of in friendships because they read social cues differently and may not recognize when “being nice” has crossed into “being used.” Teaching “grace is a CHOICE” gives them a frame for both directions: yes you can be kind, AND yes you can say no. Post alongside the grace definition BEFORE any scenario work. Return to this chart at Lesson 5.

The Pause Practice

Choosing the kind story — and noticing when the pattern says otherwise

When something happens and you’re not sure why — use the Pause Practice before you react.

I

STEP ONE

⚡

Something happens.

You are not sure why someone did what they did.

2

STEP TWO

💭

Notice your first thought.

What did your brain say? Notice it. Do not act on it yet.

3

STEP THREE

⏸

Pause.

Ask: “What is another way to see this — a kind one?”

4

STEP FOUR

➡

Act on the kind story — UNLESS the pattern tells you something different.

If this is the **first time** something has happened — give the kind story a chance.
If this has happened **over and over** — that pattern is information. Listen to it.

YOUR READ OF THE SITUATION IS DATA

If something feels wrong over and over again — **that feeling is information.**

The kind story is a place to start — *not a place to stay when someone keeps hurting you.*

Tell a trusted grown-up on your Support Web.

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

This is the most important adaptation in the whole supplement. The original Pause Practice — taught without a pattern-tracking guardrail — can train children to repeatedly override accurate threat detection. Autistic children, who are statistically more likely to be bullied AND less likely to be believed when they report it, are at particular risk from this. Step 4 has been amended to include “UNLESS the pattern tells you something different,” and the new panel makes explicit that *their read is data*. The construct (charitable interpretation) is unchanged. The guardrail is essential. Post BEFORE the scenario practice. Keep permanently.

A Note to the Teacher

What this supplement asks of you

If you are reading this, you are likely teaching the *Architecture of Grace* curriculum to a class that includes at least one autistic child. **This supplement does not ask you to teach a different curriculum. It asks you to teach the same curriculum more visibly.**

The autistic children in your room benefit when the metaphor is named alongside its meaning, when the body comes before the feeling, when the script is printed where they can see it, and when the safety floor is explicit on the chart instead of held in your head. Every neurotypical child in the room benefits from these things too. That is the secret of universal design — we did not lower the ceiling; we added more ways to reach it.

What we ask you to honor

- **Special interests are identity, not distraction.** Welcome them in Branch 1 at full volume.
- **Some children won't feel the feeling in their body — yet.** "I don't feel it anywhere" is honest data. Accept it.
- **Sentence frames may be used verbatim for a long time.** That is the lesson working, not failing.
- **Panel 1 is always private.** Never ask. Not even gently.
- **Patterns are real.** A child telling you something keeps happening is giving you information — not being negative.
- **Masking is real.** A child who looks fine may be working very hard to look fine. Watch for the cost.

What we ask you to never do

- Never force eye contact. Listening looks different in different bodies.
- Never reframe a child's accurate read of an unkind person as "you need to give grace." Grace is a choice. So is naming what is true.
- Never collect Panel 1 worksheets. Never read them. Never display them.
- Never tell an autistic child that their literal interpretation is wrong. It is the first interpretation — help them see there is also a second one, and that both are real.

A FINAL WORD

The original *Architecture of Grace · The Foundation* is a serious piece of work built on solid research, and the children in your room are lucky to have it. This supplement exists because every child in your room — autistic and otherwise — deserves a curriculum that meets them where their brain actually is, in the body they actually live in. *Thank you for the work you do. It matters more than the day will let you see.*